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The Meaning of Home Amidst Displacement: Palestinian Perspectives in *Refugees of the Revolution*

Merriam Webster defines home as: “one’s place of residence”, which, in simple terms, is a very basic and simple definition, and seems like something that everyone is able to relate to – having a place of residence. Unfortunately, though, for many refugees the meaning of home takes on a different and more nuanced meaning. Is home where you originated from? Or, is home where you sought refugeedom? In Diana Allan’s book *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, she interviews the refugees living in Shatila, a refugee camp in the southern suburbs of Beirut, Lebanon that many Palestinians live in. The Shatila refugee camp is just one of many refugee camps in Lebanon that Palestinians have sought refuge in. It was created in 1949 for Palestinian refugees, and houses almost 10,000 Palestinian refugees, as well as Syrian refugees now. Throughout her book she examines everyday life in Shatila by interviewing various refugees that have made Shatila their current, but not true, home. In these conversations with various refugees, many of whom are refugees born in exile, they recount about the stories and memories that they were told about by first-generation refugees about Palestine and the desire to soon return home to Palestine. Many also voice their need, want, and their right to return.

In Edward Said's essay "Reflections on Exile" he describes what exile means and who exiles are by reflecting on his own life as an exile and what his perception of home is, as well as the perception of home for other exiles. He opens his essay by saying that exile is an "unhealable rift forced between a human being and a native place, between the self and its true home"¹. With the ongoing political unrest in Palestine and having to seek refuge in neighboring countries in refugee camps, Palestinians are exiles and are living in exile. They have been living in exile for many years now. There is a huge rift between Palestinians and Palestine – their native place and their true home. In Hannah Arendt's Essay "We Refugees" she says that as refugees, as a refugee herself and fleeing from Nazi-Germany, that "we lost our home, which means the familiarity of everyday life. We lost our occupation, which means the confidence that we are of some use in this world"². Similarly, the Palestinians lost their homes and their occupations in turn losing their everyday life and their place in the world. Due to this rift between refugees and home, it poses the question of whether or not these refugees will ever be able to return to their home in Palestine, or whether they have to create their homes in refugee camps, or if they have to go abroad and seek refugeedom in a whole new country and start a whole new life. In Chapter 1 "Commemorative Economies" of Allan's book she is at Najdeh, a women's NGO, where Mazen, a young Palestinian American man who works with a US-based right-of-return organization says that "The right of return and the desire to go back to Palestine, to our villages, is at the center of every refugee's identity"³. Although many Palestinians have been exiled to refugee camps near and around Palestine, and have found a new home within these camps and amongst the communities that are present in these camps like Shatila, they all still want to return to their true

¹ Edward Said, "Reflections on Exile" In *Reflections on Exile and Other Essays* (Harvard University Press, 2000), 173.

² Hannah Ardent, "We Refugees" In *Menorah Journal* 31 (1943), 264.

³ Diana Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile* (Stanford University Press, 2013), 38.

home – Palestine. Later in Chapter 6 “Many Returns”, Allan says that “refugees are eloquent in their yearning for a return to Palestine”⁴. So these refugees do indeed want to return to their original home, whether or not they grew up there and have their own memories from there. For first-generation refugees, they want to return because their “right to a material and cultural patrimony”⁵ was “unjustly stripped from them”⁶ when they first had to move out of Palestine and seek refuge in Shatila. Edward Said also says that exiles are “cut off from their roots, their land, their past”⁷, which is seen with the first-generation refugees. When they had to leave their homeland of Palestine in 1948 and had to seek refuge in Shatila, or other refugee camps in the surrounding area, they were cut off from their land and their past – their home in Palestine. For refugees born in exile, they want to return because they have “communion with places they have heard about or imagined”⁸ through stories and experiences told by those who have lived in Palestine. So for all of the generations of Palestinian refugees living in Shatila there is a strong desire to return home. They believe that they have the right to return to their homeland despite being exiled, and they do have the right to return and make their home home again.

The Shatila refugee camp has been housing Palestinian refugees for almost 75 years now, meaning that there are many generations of Palestinian refugees in the camp, like first-generation refugees and refugees that were born and raised in Shatila. The first-generation refugees were those present during the initial displacement of Palestine, and some were either adults or children when they moved to Shatila. Due to this some of them have more memories of Palestine than others since some of the first-generation refugees were children when they first arrived in Shatila. Since so much time has passed since 1949, many of the first-generation refugees are

⁴ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 191.

⁵ Ibid.

⁶ Ibid.

⁷ Said, “Reflections on Exile” In *Reflections on Exile and Other Essays*, 177.

⁸ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 191.

dying off which also means that their experiences and stories of Palestine and their original “home” are also dying off. In Chapter 6 “Many Returns” of Allan’s book *Umm Ali*, a first generation refugee, died and her daughter Umm Mahmud reflects on her death. Umm Mahmud says that “first-generation refugees are seen as the last living link to a lost world, even the literal embodiment of Palestinian condition”⁹. During an interview with Allan, Umm Mahmud says that her mother always referred to Palestine as her home because that is where she is from and where she grew up. She says that her mother “was always happy in her village, in her memories”¹⁰ of Palestine and that she always viewed Palestine as her home, not Shatila. Her mother also always talked about wanting to return home – Palestine. Although Umm Ali’s children did not grow up or live in Palestine, she would recount so many memories and stories of Palestine that her children “grew to love it through her”¹¹. Due to this Umm Mahmud has a “desire to return” even while she has been living in “prolonged exile”¹². Umm Mahmud also states that there is a “significance of the passing of her parents’ generation for those left behind”¹³; because not only is the generation dying but their first-hand stories and experiences of Palestine are also dying with them, so those left behind, significantly refugees born in exile, are only left with memories and stories of Palestine. For many the disappearance of first-generation refugees is almost like “erasure of the community as a whole”¹⁴. But through these memories, stories, and experiences told by first-generation refugees many refugees born in exile also consider Palestine to be home and have a desire to return to their true home and leave Shatila. Allan says that “the continued existence of Palestine and its people, it is assumed, now depends on a consciously remembered

⁹ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 193.

¹⁰ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 192.

¹¹ Ibid.

¹² Ibid.

¹³ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 193.

¹⁴ Ibid.

history and cultural tradition.”¹⁵. Luckily some first-generation refugees, like Umm Ali, were able to recount their experiences in Palestine to their children, grandchildren, and other refugees born in exile and make them also view Palestine as home so that the desire to return home continues and does not simply die along with first-generation refugees.

Through the experiences, memories, and stories told by first-generation refugees to refugees born in exile such as children, grandchildren, and friends, many of whom have never been to Palestine, still view it as home. Many even feel a very strong sense of connection to Palestine, again, despite never being there. But it is through these recounted experiences that they feel a sense of home in Palestine. Again in Chapter 6, Allan interviews Ahmed, the youngest son of Umm Yusuf about his experience during the March of Return. The March of Return was a demonstration that occurred on May 15, 2011, which Palestinians consider to be Nakba Day which is the day that Palestinian society was deconstructed in 1948. On this day, many Palestinian refugees from Lebanon, Syria, Jordan, and Egypt used Facebook to call for protests and demonstrations on the Israel and Palestine borders. The March of Return was supposed to symbolize the right of return to Palestine for Palestinians living in refugee camps in the surrounding region. The March of Return brought together many Palestinians, those living inside or outside of refugee camps, those with varying socioeconomic backgrounds, and those of varying ages from different generations of refugeedom. Ahmed found out about the March of Return through Facebook and was compelled by the idea of it. He said that he “had never been to the border”¹⁶ and admitted that he did want to go to the border and see it for himself because he was “drawn by the desire to see Palestine with his own eyes”. When he got off the bus from Shatila to the march he said that “when I saw my country, my heart took over my mind”¹⁷ and

¹⁵ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 42.

¹⁶ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 205.

¹⁷ Ibid.

that he immediately ran to the border. Unfortunately in doing so he was shot by an Israeli soldier, but luckily Ahmed survived. This experience, though, allowed Ahmed to “sense that for once he was the protagonist, able to assert himself and make his feelings known”¹⁸. This shows that the younger generation of Palestinian refugees, the generation born in exile, have a connection to Palestine despite having never been there. And this shows that mental and emotional connection to home is much stronger than a physical connection, and that they want to really insert themselves and help to make the push for them and other refugees to return home. Through stories and experiences told to them by older generations the desire to return home to Palestine is still very strong and prevalent for the younger generations of Palestinian refugees.

There is continued unknowingness of when Palestinian refugees will be able to return home – to Palestine. Despite younger generations of refugees in Shatila wanting to return to Palestine they are “increasingly torn between the ideal of a redemptive return to a Palestinian homeland and the pragmatic desire for a secure and meaningful existence in Lebanon or abroad”¹⁹. There is a struggle for refugees in Shatila to return home due to lots of uncertainty about the state of Palestine with the ongoing Arab-Israeli conflict, as well as lack of means due to economic disparity, lack of civil rights, and a lack of political unity amongst the refugees while in Lebanon. Although these refugees first sought out refugeedom in Shatila in Lebanon in 1948 and have been living there for many years now, they still very much hold a “refugee” status within Lebanon and have yet to be given the same rights and opportunities as the Lebanese. In Vinh Nguyen’s article “Refugeetude: When Does a Refugee Stop Being a Refugee?”, he recounts the experiences of Nhan T. Le who is a Vietnamese refugee, says that “the shock of returning to Vietnam reminds Le that she is still a refugee because she has not yet settled into American

¹⁸ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 207.

¹⁹ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 194.

capitalist success”²⁰. Even though these Palestinian refugees have been living in Lebanon for almost 75 years now, many have not been able to settle into Lebanese capitalist success, similar to Le with Vietnam and the United States. Nguyen also says that “the work of seeking refuge does not end when refugees are granted political asylum; what begins instead is a life of low-wage labor, few opportunities for upward mobility”²¹. As refugees in Lebanon, the Palestinians are given far less civil rights compared to the Lebanese, which in turn does not allow for the Palestinians to hold good, high paying jobs. There is little upward mobility for the Palestinians, especially to try to earn enough money to try to move back to Palestine and create a life there. After a rally in downtown Beirut, where Palestinian refugees were protesting about the failure to uphold the right of return after the Geneva Accords were made public, Allan was sitting on the bus back to Shatila with a middle-aged woman. She says that “it is understandable people feel fed up when you consider how the Lebanese government uses our rights against us”²². She continues by saying that “on one side the government puts unbearable pressure on us by refusing to give us civil rights, and on the other side they say that we must have the right to return. I think that before talking about return, they should let us work”²³. Even though the Lebanese government seems to believe that Palestinians have the right to return to Palestine they do not do much to help the Palestinians to return. As Said says, Palestinians have a “perilous territory of not-belonging”²⁴. While living in refugee camps of countries that welcomed them, the refugees do not feel as though they belong in these welcoming countries; so, it is difficult for them to call these places of refugeedom home. Inspired by what Hannah Arendt says, Allan says that “Palestinians don’t have the ‘right to have rights’”²⁵. With a lack of civil rights and the

²⁰ Vinh Nguyen, “Refugeetude: When Does a Refugee Stop Being a Refugee?”, (Social Text 37, 2019), 110.

²¹ Nguyen, “Refugeetude: When Does a Refugee Stop Being a Refugee?”, 110.

²² Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 201.

²³ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 202.

²⁴ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 42.

²⁵ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 200.

inability to hold high paying labor, it is difficult for the Palestinians to be viewed as people in Lebanon and to make a living and money to help them to move back home. While many refugees do want to return home to Palestine, many stay and make their life in Shatila, whereas some move abroad in hopes of better civil rights and opportunities.

For some Palestinian refugees, home is not back in Palestine due to the huge rift that was created between them and their home, though some still believe in the right of return, they just do not want to return. It brings back too painful memories to return to where they were exiled from. In Allan's interview with Umm Mahmud's husband Munir, he says that:

"My life is not in Haifa, what is there for me now? . . . Still, I want the right to knock on the door of my father's house and say to the people living there, "This is my father's house, which you took from him in 1948. I understand that you are living here now, and that's okay. I don't want to live here, but I want you to acknowledge that you took this from him and from me."'²⁶

The meaning of home takes on many different meanings for refugees, because is home their homeland? Where they seeked refuge? Or somewhere else? For many their true home, and the home in their hearts and memories is Palestine. Many feel the right to return and continue their lives there. Unfortunately due to civil rights blockades made by the Lebanese government, many Palestinians in Shatila are unable to make a living and earn money to try to move back to Palestine. But also, with a lack of civil rights they do not feel as if they belong in Lebanon while living in Shatila or possibly moving elsewhere in Lebanon, or other countries in the surrounding area. So many look to possibly move abroad like to the United States or Europe. Allan says that:

"Mass displacement and the creation of diaspora were key to Palestinian nation formation, and Palestinian nationalism continues to draw on idioms of home and

²⁶ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 195.

homelessness. Alienation and exile deepen the need to reconstruct a homeland; they generate acts of imagination believed to be essential to the forging of national identity.”²⁷

Illuminating on what Allan says, Palestinian refugees, as exiles, want to reconstruct a homeland, many of which hope is to be in Palestine. Due to the complexity of the statehood of Palestine, and whether or not it really is a state, as well as the complexities with the Arab-Israeli conflict, it is difficult to know what the future holds for Palestine. This also makes it incredibly difficult for Palestinian refugees to define a home for themselves. While many do call Palestine home and want to return, it is difficult because of economic disparities and lack of civil rights, but it is also uncertain of when they can even return to Palestine – given the ongoing conflict. Meaning that the meaning of home for Palestinian refugees, as well as many other refugees, is always changing and never concrete, because their homes are always changing and they simply adapt to these changes and make home what they can given the circumstances; though their true home is almost always where they came and originated from.

²⁷ Allan, *Refugees of the Revolution: Experiences of Palestinian Exile*, 42.

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